
Introduction

As a teacher, you can participate in transdisciplinary education in various ways. You can be an initiator, join an ongoing project, serve as an expert, work as a teacher-researcher, or play a supporting role.

Currently, much transdisciplinary education starts with individual, enthusiastic teachers who set up a project with a strong interest and belief in innovative education. They seek broader support within their institution. Teachers thus function as the pioneers.

Now that more transdisciplinary education projects are emerging everywhere, you can also join existing initiatives or collaborate with other partners. Institution-wide educational events, such as an annual day or education festival, or national education conferences, are good opportunities to connect with other motivated innovators. The same applies to network organizations like Comenius (in the Netherlands) or networking via social media like LinkedIn. Also, look around within your own university for ongoing initiatives, or at other schools in the region.

Sometimes, companies and societal organizations themselves approach educational institutions with project proposals. It helps to actively express your interest in developing transdisciplinary education, to increase the chances of being connected to other enthusiasts.

There are many different ways to engage in transdisciplinary education. Throughout the TRAIL, you will learn more about the various phases of transdisciplinary education. Whether you are pioneering alone or joining an existing initiative.

Theory

Advice

Design the education collaboratively as a team, but implement it with a compact core group of educators. Ensure that students, through their own backgrounds and online resources, have access to diverse perspectives. This way, you can do justice to the complexity without running into organizational challenges.

Practice

Different practices: who brings in the substantive expertise?

When designing transdisciplinary education, it's important to consider who contributes the disciplinary perspectives — the students or the teachers. This directly affects your role as an educator.

1. ~~Single-disciplinary education, where disciplinary expertise belongs to one guide~~

2. Teacher-intensive education

In narrow interdisciplinarity, teachers provide the various perspectives. You then take on a more traditional role (*sage on the stage*) and offer content frameworks or knowledge transfer. Students are relatively more passive in this setup.

Both forms can be effective but require different design choices and teaching skills. Often, a student-intensive approach is preferred because it aligns better with contemporary, active learning and is less vulnerable to teacher absence.

Teaching formats and organization: team teaching or not?

To ensure all relevant perspectives are included in the education, co-teaching with a multidisciplinary team of educators is a logical choice. However, this is costly, vulnerable, and organizationally complex.

Therefore, a common approach is to have one main facilitator (coach), with additional content contributions from others via guest lectures, online resources, or external experts.